



■ By Mihir Srivastava

The key to dealing with terror is the timely exchange of actionable inputs among the intelligence agencies. That is what did not happen again this time when the Indian Mujahideen (IM) targeted Delhi's crowded Ghaffar Market in Karol Bagh, Connaught Place and M-Block Market in Greater Kailash-I, killing 24 and seriously injuring 50 more. "We were taken by surprise; there was no intelligence input on this possibility," says a top official of Delhi Police.

That is cold comfort for the citizens of the capital, the most heavily guarded city in the country. "Hoax bomb calls and rumours about blasts have robbed the people of Delhi of their sense of security," says Rajesh Singh, who was present when the blasts took place in Greater Kailash-I. "We have to learn to live with it." The reason for such hopelessness lay in the IM e-mail, titled "Message of Death", in which it challenged the security establishment of India to "stop if they can". IM went on to take the responsibility of the attack saying that it had accomplished "Operation BAD", that is terror strikes in Bangalore (B), Ahmedabad (A) and Delhi (D).

This is despite the fact that the Gujarat Police had, on August 15, claimed to have busted the pan-India network of SIMI while investigating serial blasts in Ahmedabad. Ten people, including the alleged mastermind behind the attack Mufti Abu Bashir, were arrested. Two months after this breakthrough, it is shocking that the security agencies were oblivious of "Operation BAD", as a result of which Delhi fell victim to the "bloody Saturday" terror attacks.

In the case of Delhi, the lapse becomes even more glaring given the fact that unlike other states, the Delhi Police comes

GRIEVED: (from left, anti-clockwise) The blast site on Barakhamba Road; a victim being taken to hospital for treatment; a father with the body of his two-year-old child and women mourning during cremation rites



REUBEN SINGH